

Session 21: Characterization and Setting in Biblical Narrative

Key Takeaways

- Biblical authors use characters as vehicles for their message primarily through showing rather than telling.
- Narrators rarely make comments in biblical narrative, and when they do, it's with small details or brief phrases.
- Biblical authors give us the trace of a character but we have to fill in the rest based on the little we know.
- The minimalist policy is very intentional. It forces us, the readers, to participate in the making of meaning.
- Biblical authors use the setting as a tool in biblical narratives to evoke memories and emotions and to generate expectations about what could happen in the story.

Characters in Biblical Narrative

Narrative and Moral Values

Narrative characters are the most effective means of communicating the moral vision of the biblical authors. But how exactly?

“Most of an author’s view of the world and the values they want to communicate are embodied in the narrative and expressed through the characters. Not only do characters serve as a narrator’s mouthpiece, but also what is and is not related about them, which of their personality traits are emphasized and which are not, these all reveal the ethical values and moral norms within the narrative. The decisions that characters are called upon to make when confronted with moral choices, and the results of their decisions provide undisputable evidence of a narrative’s ethical dimension.”

Bar-Efrat, Shimon (2004). [*Narrative Art in the Bible*](#). T&T Clark. 47.

Characters in the Bible are not so much models for behavior as they are mirrors for self-reflection. Through means of identification, the reader comes to either sympathize with a character’s challenges and choices, or they disassociate by viewing their behavior as ethically inferior or unwise.

By sympathizing with the plot-conflict of the characters, the narrator invites us to view ourselves in light of this story and its resolution.

Biblical Style in Narrative Characterization

“The Greek storytelling tendency of loading the story with details is one that modern literary practice has by and large adopted and developed. Precisely for that reason we have to adjust our habits as readers in order to bring an adequate attentiveness to the rather different narrative maneuvers characteristic of the Hebrew Bible. The underlying biblical conception of people’s character is that they’re unpredictable, constantly emerging from and slipping back into ambiguity. Thus, biblical narrative style is marked by the art of reticence.”

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art Of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books. 129.

Direct Characterization

The biblical narrators sometimes provide direction, description, or evaluation of a character, but not as often as we might assume. For example, the physical appearance of a character is mentioned occasionally, but only when relevant to the narrative, like with Joseph’s good looks, Saul’s tall stature, and Esau’s hair. The biblical narrators also occasionally give a moral evaluation of a character, like with the phrase “So and so did evil/good in the eyes of Yahweh.”

Direct characterization is not as common in the Bible as is often assumed. In *Poetics and Interpretation of Biblical Narrative*, Adele Berlin uses the illustration of two types of painting styles: realism (modern Western novels) versus impressionism or pointillism (ancient biblical narrative) (Berlin, 1994).

Instead of direct characterization, the biblical authors give us a few small details.

- Esau is hairy. In the story, this means he’s “outdoorsy” and primitive and behaves like an animal.
- Eli is old and blind. This means he is literally and relationally blind because he ignores the rebellion of his sons.
- Saul is tall and David is small. This speaks to the contrast of their characters. Saul imposes himself from above, while David humbly allows God to exalt him from below.

[In impressionist art,] “the suggestion of a thing may be more convincing than a detailed portrayal. This is due to the tendency of our brains to project meaning onto images in order to complete our expectations. We see what we expect to see, and the surrounding information guides our perception. This is why we fill in a partially drawn figure to conform to our expectations, and in some cases too much information may destroy the image. The trick, from the artist’s point of view, is how much detail to include and how much to omit. This is a good corrective for those who wish biblical stories provided more concrete details, but this is precisely its narrative technique. The gaps left in biblical narratives are intentional, so that with a few deft strokes the biblical author engages the imagination of the reader to construct a picture that is more ‘real’ than if he had filled in David or Abraham or Joseph’s portrait with more detail. Minimal representation can give maximal illusion.”

Berlin, Adele (1994). [Poetics and Interpretation of Biblical Narrative](#). Eisenbrauns.

Indirect Characterization

“Biblical narratives demonstrate a decided preference for using deeds to reveal character, letting us learn about characters through observing the way they behave in various situations. They prefer showing to telling.”

Moses kills an Egyptian, but we aren't told why. Was this justice? Is this a good or a bad decision? Abraham gives Sarah away, twice, but the narrator doesn't chime in to say this was wrong. David commands Solomon to go on an assassination spree to eliminate enemies, but this wasn't commanded by God.

Instead of moralizing about characters' decisions, biblical narrators simply show you the decision and consequences of characters' decisions and allow you to ponder the significance.

Dialogue, Speeches, and Poetry

Character Dialogue: Biblical authors use dialogue in sophisticated ways to offer a window into the motives and moral values of the character.

Speeches: Very often a narrative will pause, a key character will offer a long speech, and the reader is left to determine the character's authenticity and motives.

Examples of Key Speeches

- Joshua in [Joshua 24](#)
- Samuel in [1 Samuel 8](#) or [12](#)
- Solomon in [1 Kings 8](#)

Inset Poems: Poems are often inserted into the narrative in order to summarize the core themes of the story so far, or to preview the themes that are going to be developed in the following narrative. Often the poems use dramatic or cosmic imagery in order to show how the narrative links up to the larger scale storyline of the biblical narrative.

Examples of Key Poems/Songs

- Jacob in [Genesis 49](#)
- Moses and Miriam in [Exodus 15](#)
- Moses in [Deuteronomy 32-33](#)
- Deborah and Barak in [Judges 5](#)
- Hannah in [1 Samuel 2](#)
- David in [2 Samuel 22-23](#)

Setting

Space in Biblical Narrative

Place is a key feature of biblical narrative. As the biblical story develops, places begin to take on a symbolic/meaningful significance based on the events that happen there.

Example: Garden of Eden > The East > Babylon. The human spiral of sin and selfishness moves from the garden to Babylon (Gen. 1-11 = tragic).

- Adam and Eve are banished “to the east” ([Gen. 3](#))
- Cain is banished “to the east” ([Gen. 4](#))
- People move “to the east” to build Babylon ([Gen. 11:1-2](#))

Babylon becomes a superpower in the story that comes back to take over the family of Abraham.

Egypt, Moab, the wilderness, Bethlehem, and Jerusalem all become loaded with more and more meaning as the biblical story develops.

Time in Biblical Narrative

Pay attention to the difference between narrative time and time of narration. You can tell which events are most meaningful to the author’s message by what gets the most airtime and by what time periods are given the most textual space.

The Bible as Anti-Didactic Literature

“One you realize the Bible’s ‘anti-didactic’ style is a narrative policy, you gain insight into the role of the aesthetic subtlety of these stories. They almost always shun extended commentary or explanation, let alone homiletics [= sermoning, moralizing]. These authors intentionally leave gaps for the reader to puzzle over—discontinuities, indeterminacies, non-sequiturs, unexplained motives—and they’re fully aware of the disorienting effect this has on readers as they try to draw lessons from the past. Biblical narrators conceal the meaning of their stories to an extent seldom equalled by any other literature in history. This style was not inherited by Israel’s neighboring cultures, rather it was invented and elaborated in the Israelite tradition of narrative and it’s nothing less than deliberate. ...

In day to day life, knowledge and information and the ability to understand the meaning of events is power. But in reading the Bible, we’re constantly puzzling over the gaps in the stories [Why did Moses do that? Why did God do that?], and this is strategic: our puzzlement is an imitation of our real position in life. It exposes our ignorance about the meaning of history or our lives. Biblical stories imitate our real-life conditions of inference, as we too are daily surrounded by ambiguities, baffled and misled by appearances, reduced to piecing fragments together by trial and error of interpretation, and we’re often left in the dark about the meaning of our lives to the very end. The scarcity of commentary by the biblical narrators forces us to constantly evaluate the character’s motives and the meaning of the plot as we look for clues. It is only by sustained effort that the reader of biblical narratives can attain to the point of view that God has possessed all along. Making sense of biblical stories is to gain a sense of being human.”

Sternberg, Meir (1987). [*The Poetics of Biblical Narrative: Ideological Literature and the Drama of Reading*](#). Indiana University Press. 42, 47.

Reflection Question

Why might the narrator leave ambiguities in characterization? What is the effect of creating complex characters or leaving gaps?